affairs (DEA) to restrict corporate houses to two airports each, especially since the airports going under the hammer required massive capital. But in 2018, when the discussions were happening, many of the domestic infrastructure players were nursing bleeding balance sheets. Congress leaders had even then raised red flags but the BJP leaders argue that decisions were taken keeping in mind ease of doing business guarantees for the serious players.

On the Adani Group's foray into the defence sector, Rahul alleged that the whole India-Israel defence collaboration initiative had been handed over to Adani on a platter, with all bilateral manufacturing contracts going to the group. Again, this is happening when the Adanis have zero prior exposure in the sector. Military observers, though, feel the allegations are just part of a 'political slugfest'. On the issue of prior experience, they say no private Indian concern would meet those qualification parameters in what was hitherto a public sector monopoly. What they can do is tie up with a foreign entity and collectively gain experience, which readies them for the pre-qualification stage. "Here, the only question is whether any pre-qualification criteria were relaxed [for the Adanis] or not," says a defence expert. Apart from the missile agreement with Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL), an Indian government-owned aerospace and defence electronics company, Adani and their partner Israeli firms got the drone, radar and communication systems contracts.

FOR RAHUL, THE CHARGES ARE A VINDICATION OF HIS FREQUENT CLAIM THAT THE MODI GOVT HAS BEEN UNFAIRLY BACKING TWO TOP BUSINESS EMPIRES

A key official at the Ministry of Defence (MoD) points to the Tata Group's entry into aircraft manufacturing. "The Tatas had never made aircraft, but they have tied up with Airbus and are now making C295 transport planes here in India. Similarly, L&T has been roped into the nuclear submarine programme. They too had no previous experience," says the official, adding that the only thing that matters is the financial and technical capability of the company to carry out the contract.

Meanwhile, Adani's reaction to the recent developments has been to invoke nationalism and even call the Hindenburg report an attack on India itself. The grandstanding, though, has failed to impress the Opposition as both houses of Parliament witnessed several adjournments amid protests and sloganeering. In a fiery intervention in the Lok Sabha, Trinamool Congress MP Mahua Moitra denounced the government for favouring Adani, saying, "The pride of India is not the wealth of one individual, the pride of India lies in

TARGET MODI

This is not the first time Opposition parties have accused PM Narendra Modi of breaking rules to facilitate the Adani empire's expansion



↘ THE ADANI EMPIRE'S RISE HAS BEEN FACILITATED BY MODI, FIRST AS GUJARAT CM AND THEN AS PM. HE TURNED A BLIND EYE TO PAST ALLEGATIONS OF IRREGULARITIES AGAINST THE ADANI GROUP

PM Modi has never acknowledged any such relationship. Adani Group chief Gautam Adani says he benefited from the economic policies of Congress government as well

↘ PM MODI INFLUENCED GOVERNMENTS IN OTHER COUNTRIES SUCH AS ISRAEL, BANGLADESH, AUSTRALIA AND SRI LANKA TO AWARD LUCRATIVE CONTRACTS TO THE ADANI GROUP

The PM has not responded to these allegations. Without directly referring to this allegation, Modi said in Lok Sabha: "The Opposition leaders contradict their own statements. They say that India's global image has weakened since 2014. Now they say that India bullies foreign governments. They must make up their mind first"

↘ MODI TAKES ALONG ADANI DURING HIS FOREIGN TRIPS

BJP leader Nishikant Dubey has publicly challenged Rahul Gandhi to prove this